

in her 60s, she has gotten a second job reviewing legal documents. My dad is 71. He currently drives for a ride-sharing app.

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We internalize our experiences and scripts at a very young age and it's really hard to make them unstick. They get passed down from generation to generation. Meme believed life was pain, so why not spend to surround yourself with beauty? And despite my dad's rebellious, hippie instincts, his disease pushed him to follow that line of thought. I watched my mom's mom, Lee, work herself literally to death, and I took away the message that it's not worth it to never spend money waiting for a day when you can. That day might never come.

In order to start deconstructing and fixing your own ways of thinking about money, you need to dig into the past and see what you were taught—consciously and subconsciously. Those messages may be burrowed deep, and at one point they may have protected you, but ask yourself: Are they still serving your best interests? Or is it time to let your family's money scripts go and make your own?

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Growing up, it doesn't usually occur to you that different families have different financial situations until you start seeing the way other people live—either by sleeping over at friends' houses or observing the lifestyles of the characters on your favorite television shows. (Dial it back, *The OC*.) But still, you tell yourself you're not less than, just *different*, or that TV mansions aren't real anyway.

Despite, or maybe because of, how limited things were, I had a pretty good childhood. We always had dress-up clothes donated by my grandmas and aunt. We had Barbie dolls I destroyed with Sharpies to the face. (Sorry!) We went to McDonald's and Pizza Hut. I played outside, biking and climbing trees. I read Babysitter's Club and Nancy Drew books from both the local and school libraries. We went to free events like carnivals and parades and concerts.

I took gymnastics classes. Even though I sort of realized I couldn't buy the nicer leotards the other girls had, I still got to go to class. We went camping. We